

Justin Helmer

Principal Engineer · AI Platform · Web Platform · Full Stack
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San Francisco Bay Area, CA

SUMMARY

Principal Engineer with 18+ years building web, platform, AI, and enterprise systems at scale. Founding engineer on AI-driven behavioral analytics and personalization systems serving billions of requests per day. Most recently architected Webflow's internal AI platform, working directly with teams across the organization to shape technical direction, vendor evaluation, and AI strategy. Led acquisition integrations as a principal technical anchor, including zero-downtime integration work for Webflow's Intellimize launch. Built engineering hiring systems and led cultural change across multiple organizations.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- Led acquisition integration work across Intellimize and Vidoso at Webflow, aligning architecture, product direction, teams, and operating models under accelerated timelines.
- Founding engineer on AI-driven behavioral analytics and personalization systems operating at billions of requests per day with four-nines uptime across customer-controlled web environments and third-party integrations.
- Rebuilt enterprise authorization systems across Intellimize and Webflow, including fine-grained access control, entitlement modeling, and zero-downtime cross-stack migration.
- Rearchitected Macy's browser and BFF platform during the desktop-to-mobile shift, serving peak consumer traffic across Macy's mobile and web commerce at Black Friday/Cyber Monday scale.

EXPERIENCE

Webflow *Apr 2024 – May 2026*

San Francisco Bay Area · 2 yrs 2 mos

Principal Engineer *Oct 2025 – May 2026 · 8 mos*

- Architected Webflow's internal AI platform by working directly with every AI initiative across the organization, shaping technical direction, vendor evaluation, and shared platform strategy to align AI investment with product and business outcomes.
- Led AI-native engineering operations, including development tooling for AI-assisted work at scale and technical planning with enterprise AI operations and senior leadership.
- Anchored the Vidoso acquisition integration across architecture, product direction, team alignment, and engineering culture.
- Chaired Webflow's engineering hiring working group, improving evaluation rubrics, calibration, interviewer practices, and signal quality.
- Established Webflow's Argentina engineering team operating model, including collaboration norms and integration patterns for distributed execution.

Senior Staff Engineer *Apr 2024 – Oct 2025 · 1 yr 7 mos*

Joined via Intellimize acquisition

- Led integration-critical workstreams after Webflow's Intellimize acquisition across authorization, platform foundations, and product launch readiness; unblocked the critical path for Webflow Conf with zero downtime.
- Rebuilt authorization from site/workspace entitlements toward enterprise fine-grained access controls, including cross-stack migration work that supported enterprise readiness.

Intellimize *Mar 2019 – Apr 2024*

San Francisco Bay Area · Acquired by Webflow Apr 2024 · 5 yrs 2 mos

Senior Principal Engineer *Nov 2021 – Apr 2024 · 2 yrs 6 mos*

- Founding engineer and core architect for AI-driven behavioral analytics, experimentation, and personalization systems serving billions of requests per day with four-nines uptime across customer-controlled web environments.
- Partnered with the CTO and Chief Architect on experimentation infrastructure, AI optimization, and LLM-based content generation from architecture through production.
- Built Intellimize's engineering hiring function from scratch, including role definition, interview design, calibration, and senior candidate evaluation.

Principal Frontend Engineer *Mar 2019 – Nov 2021 · 2 yrs 9 mos*

- Designed and built the first generation of Intellimize's personalization, behavioral analytics, experimentation, and performance-critical frontend systems.

Macy's *Jun 2013 – Mar 2019*

San Francisco Bay Area · 5 yrs 10 mos

Software Architect *Sep 2017 – Mar 2019 · 1 yr 7 mos*

- Rearchitected Macy's browser and BFF platform for the mobile era, replacing desktop-first assumptions across consumer commerce traffic at Black Friday/Cyber Monday scale.

- Delivered progressive image enhancement that improved key performance metrics by 50%+ across high-revenue shopping flows, including Black Friday/Cyber Monday traffic.

Senior Engineer Jun 2013 – Aug 2017 · 4 yrs 3 mos

- As a founding engineer on Macy's mobile web platform, helped evolve a consumer-scale codebase through a major browser-stack transition and shaped frontend architecture decisions across the organization.

Technical Lead, Emerging Technologies Jan 2015 – Oct 2015 · 10 mos

- Designed a rapid-delivery framework selected by leadership for a high-stakes initiative; it became a bootstrap standard for Macy's in-store associate tools.

M29 Technology and Design Apr 2008 – May 2013

San Luis Obispo · 5 yrs 2 mos

Senior Engineer – R&D Apr 2008 – May 2013 · 5 yrs 2 mos

- Built full-stack product systems in a high-velocity R&D environment, developing the pragmatic engineering foundation later applied to consumer-scale commerce, personalization, and platform work.

Independent Advisor & Contractor Nov 2013 – Present

Ongoing alongside full-time roles

Advise founders and engineering leaders on architecture, hiring, team formation, and build-vs-buy decisions across early-stage and scaling organizations.

CORE CAPABILITIES

AI Platform & Applied AI Systems Production AI systems, vendor evaluation, platform strategy, AI-assisted engineering workflows, experimentation, personalization, and behavioral analytics.

Technical Strategy & Org Alignment Cross-functional architecture, executive technical advising, product/engineering alignment, roadmap shaping, acquisition integration, and high-stakes decision support.

Web Platform Architecture at Scale Browser/BFF architecture, high-traffic consumer commerce, performance engineering, customer-controlled web environments, and resilient third-party integrations.

Enterprise Authorization & Access Control Entitlement modeling, fine-grained permissions, multi-tenant access control, cross-stack migrations, zero-downtime rollout, and enterprise readiness.

Engineering Craft, Culture & Hiring Engineering standards, cultural change, hiring systems, interview design, calibration, signal quality, interviewer development, and senior technical evaluation.